



Harvesting a LEGACY

With items related to the Mahatma turning into objects of trade, India's will to preserve its heritage seems weak

By Uday Mahurkar

Every once in a while, the issue of Gandhi's legacy and its relevance crops up, with not much clarity or definitive answers. There is, however, one area where the Mahatma's legacy continues to inspire and grow in popularity and profitability: international auction houses. With some frequency, Gandhi-related items pop up at auctions where astronomical sums are paid for a piece of the prophet of

peace. Yet, the people who profit the most are collectors and sellers who have made a fortune out of buying Gandhi memorabilia from a variety of sources and then, after a decent interval, putting them up for auction. The man who heads the list is barely known except to collectors and sellers, mostly Gandhians or Gandhi's surviving relatives and colleagues, who have fallen on hard times. He is a German called Peter Ruhe who spends much of his time in Gujarat, collecting items relating to Gandhi.

Ruhe's name first surfaced early this year when industrialist Vijay Mallya spent \$1.8 million (over Rs 9 crore) to ensure that four of Gandhi's belongings returned to India. The seller was American James Otis who auctioned them through an American auctioning firm, Antiquorum Auctioneers, in New York. The items comprised Gandhi's most famous belongings—his trademark spectacles, sandals, pocket watch and a plate and bowl from which he ate. The auction immediately triggered speculation as to how the items found their way to Otis who revealed that the items had come to him through Ruhe. That admission also revealed the source of such valuable items: Gandhi's nephew and his photographer Kanu Gandhi whose late widow Abha (one of the two girls on whose shoulder Gandhiji used to rest his arms while walking) had been close to Ruhe. The German's relationship with Kanu, who passed away in 1986, and later Abha, was well known. Ruhe had first met them in the early 1980s when he declared himself an admirer who wanted to